



Panasonic's DMP-BD35 Blu-ray player

Portable DVD players cost between Rs 8000 and Rs 15,000.

DVD players with recorder. There are very few of these available in India because they are expensive. DVD players with recorder come in two models: with hard disk and without hard disk. In the hard disk model you can store the content from a television or video camera onto the hard disk and retrieve it later. It also provides facilities like pausing the live television programme, periodic timer recording and editing. In the model without the hard disk, you can only record on the optical disk.

DVD players with recorder range

from Rs 7000 to Rs 15,000.

Blu-ray DVD players. This is an altogether different optical disk technology that is compatible with full high-definition (HD) video and audio. The Blu-ray players are compatible with DVDs, but when used with Blu-ray disks these offer a much superior picture and sound experience. They also have additional features like Bonusview and BD-Live.

The Blu-ray format was developed to enable recording, rewriting and playback of HD video as well as storage of large amount of data. It allows more than five times the storage capacity of traditional DVDs and can hold

up to 25 GB on a single-layer disk and 50 GB on a dual-layer disk. This extra capacity and use of advanced video and audio codes offers an excellent high-definition experience.

Blu-ray players are compatible with full MPEG2 encoding as well as MPEG4 and VC1 and deliver superior surround sound with up to 7.1 channels of theatre-quality sound.

At present, Blu-ray players are expensive. But, by the end of this year, these are expected to cost under Rs 20,000.

Do your homework first

Pradeep Kumar Ramachandran, director-marketing (AVM), Philips India, says that the technology is always changing, so plan to buy the latest technology that is not only compatible with the disks you have but can also handle the Blu-ray disks currently coming into the market. Buying for the future means you aren't buying again in a few years.

Think how do you want to use the DVD player. Are you connecting your new DVD player to just a TV or planning to make it part of your home theatre system?

Most TV sets are compatible with all DVD players, so TV-DVD player compatibility shouldn't be a problem. DVD players have video jacks (RCA style) or S-video output. Almost all TVs produced in the last 15 years are equipped with these standards. At the top of the scale is Component video output, which gives the best-quality picture, especially with large-screen TV sets of all types.

In case you have a very old television without 'AV' (or video) input connectivity, you may have to purchase an additional AV-to-RF converter to suit your television.

If your TV has Component video (Y, Cb, Cr), S-video or simple Video input, connect any of the following outputs of your DVD player to the TV set: Component video for best-quality picture, S-Video for moderate quality and Video (CVBS) for normal quality

Blu-ray players: Are they really that good?

Rajnish Taneja, senior engineer-technical, Intex Technologies (India), says that apparently, Blu-ray players look similar to DVD players. The players look the same, the disks look the same and even the disk menus are similar. Function wise, Blu-ray is definitely better on all counts. The improvements are better image and audio quality and presence of extra special features.

There will be more choices for you once costs come down and more production houses start offering Blu-ray disks.

ADVANTAGES

Image quality. It is indeed superior in a Blu-ray player. The maximum resolution of Blu-ray is 1920x1080 (1080p), while DVD is limited to 720x480 (480p). Beyond resolution, Blu-ray also uses better video-compression methods, resulting in higher contrast and richer colours.

Audio quality. Audio quality is also better. New high-resolution soundtrack formats, such as Dolby True HD and DTS-HD Master Audio, could sound exactly the same as the music director and audio engineers intended.

Special features. Blu-ray players have additional special features over regular DVD players. The most basic innovation is the pop-up menu, which allows you to access the menu functions while the movie continues to play. Other innovations may include picture-in-picture video commentary and the ability to download new content right from your Blu-ray player.

DISADVANTAGES

Cost. At the moment, Blu-ray players are costly. One could go for one-time investment in the player but may find difficulty in building and maintaining a Blu-ray library.

Available titles. Another downside is the small number of titles available on Blu-ray. Currently, only about 970 Blu-ray titles are available, compared to more than 90,000 on DVD. So it's possible that you may not find all of your favourite movies on Blu-ray.

Load times. Sanjeev Jain, PBH consumer electronics, Videocon, informs that when Blu-ray players first came out, it could take more than three minutes to load a movie. Since then, players have become much faster, but these still don't compare with the speed of loading a DVD. While simple Blu-ray movies can load in about 20 seconds on a good Blu-ray player, movies with complex menus still take close to a minute and a half to get to the actual movie, regardless of the player.